

THE BREAK STATEMENT

A NOVEL BY JAMES MCGUIGAN JR.



The Break Statement

By James J. McGuigan Jr.

Introduction:

The Material

We are taught that logic is the way to figure things out. We learn all these formulas and steps. We think that if we just follow them, we will find the answer. We try to solve problems like they are math equations. We look for ways to do things.

Nobody tells us what to do when the problem we are trying to solve is our own life.

I started authoring this story as a way to keep track of my life. I wanted to write about the times I had to start over at 6:00 PM, the way the air in my room felt cold and fake and the way people only seemed to care about me when they needed something. I was going to write about my life as a tutor, a coder, and a photographer and how I dealt with all the noise and distractions at home.

Logic has a way of taking over. When the things that happen in our lives get too mixed up with people trying to control us and hurt us, our whole system can get messed up. This is the story of what happened when I had to start over. It is the story of how I turned my life into a process, how my memories became the things that mattered most and how my dog, a silver Husky and my two cats helped me build a life.

Before you start reading remember this: my story is not like a math problem. Things will not always add up. The information will sometimes be wrong. The person I am at the beginning of the story may not be the same person at the end.

Welcome to my story. It is ready to be read.

CHAPTER 1

[INITIALIZING...]

The system rebooted at 6:00 PM. That is how it felt anyway. The slow and flickering ascent from a dreamless sleep into a room that always felt like it was rendering at a lower resolution than the digital worlds I preferred.

The sun had already conceded the sky leaving my room in a state of pixelated grey.

I reached out my hand heavy and sluggish to adjust the temperature. The air conditioner, a piece of legacy hardware I had installed earlier hummed with a low frequency vibration that rattled the window frame.

It was a synthetic cold.

I needed it.

The chill kept the variables sharp.

Beside the bed Ghost my Husky puppy was a shimmering presence.

Ghost does not bark she only whimpers, an high pitched frequency that sounds more like a corrupted audio file than a dog.

Ghost watched me wake with an knowing patience a shadow waiting for her primary user to come back online.

Then there are the others.

Shadow, the Bombay cat, his tooth causing a slow and steady leak of drool that spoke of a vulnerability I have learned to mask.

Rocket, the Tuxedo he was perched high tucked into an impossible corner of the shelf his green eyes fixed on me like a pair of status LEDs.

Rocket did not blink.

Rocket sat there like a biological security camera, a silent observer recording the minute oscillations of my hands the rhythmic expansion of my chest.

I wonder what Rocket sees in the dark when my monitor goes black.

I moved through the house like a ghost in my life.

The soreness from the basketball game with Waleed, Rohit and Nick was a persistent error message in my joints.

We are older, Rohit. I am twenty-nine while the rest of them are still navigating the turbulent and shallow waters of their early twenties.

It shows in their logic.

Waleed is a connection we find our common ground in Halal spots and the quiet corners of Muslim owned coffee shops.

I stick to chocolate Waleed prefers the sharp and carbonated sting of a seltzer refresher.

Even there the noise of the other looms.

I opened my laptop the screen a blinding rectangle of pure light.

Discord was already alive with the chatter of friends from Australia, a cluster of avatars thousands of miles away, safer and more predictable than the people in my own hallway.

I watched them play Valorant, their voices a symphony of callouts and laughter while I retreated into the gothic and stylish violence of Devil May Cry.

It is a way to learn is it not?

I am a tutor.

I spend my working hours helping students navigate the beautiful logic of Indian mathematics.

Today was the Greatest Common Divisor, the algorithm.

Remainder, plug in substitute create the formula for x and y solve for n.

It is a system.

It is predictable.

If you follow the steps the truth reveals itself.

Human beings do not follow steps.

Human beings are bugs in a system that refuses to patch itself.

I thought about Abby and Alex.

The drama was a cloying thing, a series of recursive lies that I had been dragged into.

Abby, twenty-one. Carrying the heavy and jagged shards of past trauma

Alex, twenty three and possessed by an obsession that looks like love but feels like a firewall.

They tried to make me a variable in their conflict a lie about a liking that did not exist.

I cut them off.

I had to.

At twenty nine the stress of their high school level theatrics feels like a memory leak draining my resources.

I am the observer.

I am the one who sees the code. Refuses to be the variable.

As I started my laundry the thud of the machine echoing Rockets unblinking gaze I felt the first ripple of the shift.

Something that was not math or drama.

I looked at the photography website I had just built the lines, the encrypted Venmo setup.

Everything was in order.

Everything was controlled.

Rocket was still watching.

As the air, in the room grew colder the edges of the screen seemed to bleed into the shadows of the room.

The digital was no longer an escape.

The digital was becoming the environment.

I was the only process left running.

The clock on the taskbar clicked over until 3:00 AM. It is the zone, the hour when the internet changes from a busy place to a dark and empty space. My attention was divided between the window where I was working on automation scripts and the Discord channel where the Australians were still chatting. Their voices were a background noise, a connection to a world where the sun was shining.

I play games to escape. That is the truth. Whether it is the action of *Devil May Cry* or the tough worlds of *Elden Ring* these virtual spaces are the only ones where the rules make sense. In a game if you die you know why. You made a mistake you timed something you failed to solve a problem. In the world things are messy. People like Abby and Alex are unexpected. Can ruin everything.

I was working on a tool for an operating system, something that would make automation easy to use. It is ironic. I spend my nights trying to make technology easier for humans. I spend my days trying to avoid interacting with humans.

- The Husky moved at my feet. She gets anxious when I leave her alone. It feels like a weight on my ankles. She needs me to be there even if I am just sitting in a chair staring at a screen.
- The Tuxedo cat however was different.

He was still sitting on his perch staring at me. He was not really looking at me. He was staring at me. It is a feeling like I am just a window that he is looking through.

"You see it too, don't you?" I said quietly. The Australians laughed in the background. It sounded like it was coming from, inside my head.

I looked back at my code. It was a loop. *While true do X*. It is the foundation of everything I build. Tonight, it felt different. I started thinking about statistics and probabilities. What are the chances that a group of people will turn on you at the time? What are the chances that a cat would stare at a point for four hours without blinking?

I opened a new tab and looked at my photography website. The photos I took looked different now. In one shot a blurry figure seemed to be looking at the camera. It was a trick of the light.

As I reached for my hot chocolate, I realized the room had gotten even colder. The air conditioner was still humming, there was a new draft, a sharp chill that was coming from the direction of the Tuxedo cat.

- He was no longer staring at me.
- He was staring at the door.
- The Husky had stopped breathing.

She was not dead just waiting for a sound that had not happened yet. I put my hands back on the keyboard. My fingers were shaking. The escape was not working. Reality was starting to seep into the screen.

CHAPTER 2

The silence on the Discord channel was really weird tonight. It was not the quiet time between matches or when people are focused on something. It was like an empty space. I spoke into the mic asking a question about the next round, but my voice seemed to disappear before it even reached the computer. There was no light around my picture. No one answered. For a moment I felt like I was invisible like a ghost in the world I used to escape my life.

I looked out of the window. The automation script was done. *Process complete. 0 Errors*. It was perfect. In the world of computers, I am in control, I create order. When I leaned back my sore joints reminded me of the real world I was trying to ignore.

My mind kept going towards Emma. We were there at the wedding, the life, the successful conclusion that people promised you if you do things right. Emma found a different path. She got close to someone on Journeys, which wanted to watch a car crash in motion. COVID was already making things tough. She just let go. Now thinking about her is like a mistake in my code that I cannot erase, a problem that comes up sometimes to remind me that trust is something you can never really count on.

I live with my family technically. On the side of that door is a shared hallway, a space that should have the familiar sounds of home. At 4:00 AM the hallway is like a dark tunnel. The Husky is still staring at it, her ears perked up. Usually, the tension in this room is the cats picking on the dog a weird power game where the cats are in charge and the dog is scared. This was different. The cats were not picking on the dog. They were waiting.

I picked up my camera, the weight of the lens feeling solid in my hand. I am good at taking pictures. I do not take pictures. My shots are exactly clear, taken at the moment. I looked through the pictures from today pictures of Waleed, Rohit, Nick. The basketball court, the Halal spot, the coffee shop. Clear faces, edges.

Then I saw it.

A picture of the Tuxedo cat was taken an hour ago. He was sitting on his shelf looking at me. The focus was perfect, the light from the monitor casting a blue glow on his fur. In the reflection of his green eyes, I did not see myself. I did not see the room.

I saw a woman standing in the hallway behind me. She was thin her hair was a blonde color she was wearing a dark jacket with a small logo on the chest. *Journeys*.

My heart was racing like a trapped bird. I did not turn around. I could not. I looked at the screen of the camera zooming in on the world in the cats pupil. It was Emma. Her face was wrong. It was too pale her eyes were too wide as if she were the one who was scared.

"Emma?" I whispered.

The Discord channel came to life. "Yo, Jimmy? You there? We have been calling you for five minutes. Your mic was dead."

I let out a breath I did not know I was holding. I looked at the reflection in the monitor. Nothing. Just me, the light of the screen and the Tuxedo cat still watching from the shelf. I looked at the picture again.

The reflection in the cats eyes was gone. Just a blur of light.

I wiped my hand across my forehead feeling the sweat. I need to finish this automation project. I need to get to the math to the logic that makes sense. Because the air in the hallway was not just cold. It smelled like the air in a mall shoe store.

The Tuxedo cat just blinked. He never blinks.

Monday was coming. The change from the freedom of the weekend to the week of tutoring always felt like a crash. I have the students from Monday to Thursday. There are a lot of college freshmen and sophomores who are struggling with things like Calculus II and Data Structures. I spend my days explaining things like how to make a function and how to make a mathematical proof make sense.

I have a cat. His name is Ghost. It is a name for him. Tonight, he was in a mood. He was hissing at my dog whenever she got too close. My dog is like a follower. She always follows me around. Ghost does not like her. He thinks she is beneath him. This makes the air in the room feel weird.

My phone was buzzing on the desk. I knew it was Abby without looking. She had called me six times already. Each time she left a message saying sorry. She wants us to be friends again. She wants me to forgive her for lying and causing drama. She used my friend Alex to make herself feel better. Now Alex is not around anymore. Abby keeps calling. Her voice feels like a thing in my ear. I did not answer. Some things are too much to deal with.

To get my mind off things I went back to working on my computer tools. I am making some plugins for accessibility. I want to make it so people can

talk to their computers and have them understand. I also want to make it, so messages are private. It is about being in control. It is about being heard. Understood. As I looked at my code, I realized something.

I am making tools to help people communicate. I am also pushing away the people in my life.

I evaluated my talk-to-text tool. I spoke into the microphone. "The thing that we all have in common is the silence we keep."

The computer did not type what I said.

I am still in the hallway.

I was surprised. I checked to see if there were any errors. Everything was working fine. I tried again. "Evaluating one, two three."

He does not see me.

I pushed my chair back. The legs made a noise on the floor. Ghost stood up. I started growling. My dog. Hiding behind my desk. I looked at the door. It was closed.

I went back to my computer. I tried to fix the problem. It was a glitch. Then I got a message on Discord. It was from someone, with no name or picture.

"Abby says she's sorry " the message said. ". Emma says you're not."

The room felt weird. I looked at my phone. There were no messages. I looked at my computer. The message was gone.

I am twenty-nine years old. I teach logic. I solve problems. I know that everything has a cause. As I stood there in my room, I realized that things were not making sense.

The strange things were starting to feel real. The week had just started.

The walls of my room are thinner than they look. In the quiet of the 5:00 AM hour I can hear my father's breath from down the hall. It is a sound that defines my house now as a reminder of my father's body in revolt. My father has been a smoker for long as I can remember a man whose life was fueled by nicotine and eventually a heavy dependence on Oxycontin. My father is on life support now or as he was my father is fighting his way back trying to prove my father can breathe on his own long enough to qualify for a lung transplant. The fear is there is a shadow in my father's room. My father is terrified to sleep, terrified that if my father lets go of consciousness my father's lungs will simply forget their job. My father is winding off the Oxy down to the minimum of pain killers and the withdrawal makes my house feel like a pressure cooker.

Then there is my mother. My mother's stress is a kind of toxin. My mother wants me to be a teacher, a profession that fits into my mother's worldview. I do what my mother wants. I am going through the motions of getting a math teaching degree checking the boxes saying the things. My real goal is a Masters in Data Science and another in Mathematics. I am building a life in the shadows of my mother's expectations, a life my mother will never fully understand.

My sister is seven months pregnant now. My sister is a buffer or at least my sister tries to be. My sister fights with me not because my sister is angry at me. Because my sister needs a target that is not my parents. My sister needs to vent the frustration of watching my parents tear each other apart. Since I am the one who stays quiet, I am the easiest outlet.

I have become an expert at leaving. When the shouting starts or when my mother's pressure becomes a weight I simply leave. If not physically then mentally. I retreat into my room with my Husky, or I drive until the hours of the morning seeking the anonymity of the dark streets. My room is my fortress, my animals the ones who know the real me.

Work offers no break. My boss, Chiyao, is a master of control. Chiyao hovers, her presence a frequency that never lets me settle. Chiyao piles on tasks pressuring me in the moment demanding my time as if it were hers. I say yes to Chiyao until Chiyao goes away a shield for the students who come to us for help. They feel the pressure of the cold atmosphere Chiyao creates. I try to be the bridge for them the one who explains the logic of a differential equation or the structure of a binary tree without the added weight of Chiyao's expectations.

Today as I sat at my desk preparing for the Monday rush, I received a message on my tutoring channel. It was someone I did not recognize asking for sessions. It was strange that the website is not public yet. I have not been promoted to it. Only a handful of people even know it exists.

I looked at the message back at my father's room. My father's breath stopped for a second then resumed, a gasp.

"Everything okay, dad?" I called out my voice a whisper.

No answer. Just the hum of the air conditioner. The steady gaze of the Tuxedo cat on the shelf.

I turned back to the screen. I had a photo to edit; a basketball shot of Waleed mid-jump. As I opened the file the colors looked off. The sunlight

was too bright, the shadows too deep. I looked at the message again. The senders name was a string of numbers.

I deleted it. I do not have time for problems. I have a family to take care of a father to watch over and a boss to deal with. The mystery can wait. My life is already demanding enough.

CHAPTER 3

Monday morning hit me like a ton of bricks. Going from my room to the high-pressure tutoring center was always a shock. I help around ten students a day with a six-hour marathon where I am constantly switching between linear algebra, data structures, and basic programming. It is a never-ending stream of students stressed about their studies. Each one gets two or three hours with me. I have to be "on" the whole time even with Chiyao breathing down my neck.

Chiyao does not just manage; she micromanages. She hovers over my shoulder while I am explaining a proof jumping in with extra tasks or minor corrections that do not help. I have learned to agree with her to avoid trouble. It is a survival tactic. I am calm and helpful to the students who look at her with the wary exhaustion I feel. They do not feel welcome when she is around, so I try to make the space safe for them to mess up and learn.

When I am working privately, I charge fifty dollars an hour. It is a world. I am in charge I set the pace. I connect directly with the student. At the center I am just a small part of Chiyaos machine, a buffer between her intensity and the students desperation.

Things are not much better at home. The latest argument is about the family savings. My dad, who does not have time left, wants to spend it all. He wants to do what he wants while he is still alive an act of defiance against a body that is failing him. My mom and sister are horrified. They see the savings as a safety net a future they are trying to protect while they see it as money that will not matter when he is gone.

It is strange. When it is just me and him, he is normal. We have conversations about the day, the weather, the animals. There is an understanding between us, a shared silence that does not need to be filled with justifications or demands. The moment my mom enters the room everything changes. The "normal" man disappears, replaced by a fighter a man who uses his breath to argue and assert control he has lost in every other area of his life.

I am stuck in the middle. My sister picks fight with me just to avoid blaming others for the tension. She is seven months pregnant and her hormones and fear for the future make her sharp and unpredictable. She attacks my choices, my future, the way I spend my time. Anything to keep from acknowledging the crumbling foundation of our family.

I think back to the trip to the city two weeks ago with Alveena and Manha. New York was a kind of chaos, but it was a break. I took a lot of photos that day. The angles of the skyscrapers the blur of the crowds the quiet moments of Alveena and Manha against the backdrop of a city that does not care about your problems. I have not looked at them since. I have been too busy editing basketball shots, too busy being agreeable to James for Chiyao, too busy watching my dad decline.

As I finished my student of the day a girl struggling with a recursive function, I felt my phone vibrate. It was not Abby this time. It was an email notification from my photography website.

New booking request: The City. Night. No faces.

I stared at the screen. The request was vague. The offer was double my usual rate. I looked up to see Chiyao watching me from, across the room her eyes narrowed, her hand already reaching for a stack of assignments.

I looked back at the email. *Accept?*

I hit remove. Not today. Today I just need to breathe. If only my dad could say the same.

I find it weird to be useful. To be the person people come to when they are having trouble figuring out their lives but not the person they come to when they just want someone to talk to. I felt this way a lot when I was in the city with Alveena and Manha. They have a time to talk to people, and their lives are controlled by rules and boundaries that I do not fully understand. I was like a bridge for them, the one who knew the streets and the angels, the one who could manage the noise of New York without getting overwhelmed. Something did not feel right.

Manha seems like she does not like me all. When she is quiet it is not a silence it is like a wall. Alveena on the hand seems like she is trying to figure out how useful I can be to her. She is taking math classes. She knows that I am a tutor. I can tell she is thinking about how much she can get from me if it is worth spending time with me to get a good grade. It feels more like we are just tolerating each other than being friends like we are just using each other for our own gain with the city skyline as a background.

I am used to it. I am the tutor of the analytical person, the one who makes things work out. At home, my value is tied to what I can do for others. My mother thinks of me as a teacher, someone with whom she can rely. I am taking education classes to make her happy. Secretly I am planning to study Data Science and Math which is what I really want to do. It is like I am

living two lives, teaching and learning at the time keeping the two worlds separate by force of will.

Even photography, the one thing I do for myself is starting to get me attention that I do not want. People tell me my photos are professional and impressive. They see how clear and exact they are, how I can capture a moment without any blur or emotion. Then they want a piece of it.

Abby called me again. This time she did not just apologize, she asked me to take her picture. Just. Me, a camera, and the harsh reality of her past. It was a move trying to get me back into her life by appealing to my pride as a photographer. She knows I take pride in my work she knows I love taking well-composed shots. But I know what happens when I take her picture the truth becomes something she can manipulate until it is not recognizable anymore.

I told Abby I was busy my voice was flat.

I looked at the photos from the city again. Alveena and Manha were clear their faces sharp against the neon lights. They looked professional, yes. They looked distant like people in a study rather than friends.

At home, my father's spending is getting out of control. He bought something today I do not even know what it is, a box that arrived and caused another fight between my mother and sister. He is spending all our savings like he is trying to get rid of it all like he is running away from something. My sister is pregnant. She was yelling at him for being selfish.

I stayed in my room. I opened my computer. I started a script that would help me clean up the data for a project I am working on. The idea is simple: if the data is empty removed, if the data is repeated, combine it.

If only I could do that with my life. I would remove the people who are using me to combine the relationships that are not real and clean up all the noise until the only sound left was my own breathing.

As I typed, I felt like someone was watching me. Ghost, my cat was on his shelf waiting. He was not hissing he was just waiting. The air in the room was starting to smell like an old shoe store again.

I did not turn around. I just kept typing. If the data is empty remove it. The data is never empty. It is always there waiting to be seen.

The house is getting filled up with toys fast. It is like something out of a dream with all these bright lights and weird noises everywhere. My father found this website called Temu. Now he buys all these gadgets that come to our house every other day. There are flashlights that are super powerful

little hover things that fly around and make a lot of noise and boards that light up with a weird blue glow. My father spends all our money on these things because he wants to make our house feel happier. He does not like that he is getting sick and wants to make everything feel better with all these lights and noises.

My mother gets really upset about how money we are spending and how much electricity we are using. My father just ignores her and keeps playing with his new toys. He likes the way they sound and look. This is a weird time for our family.

I am the one who does not get into fights with my parents. I just tune out. Go to my own world. I can do this easily. I just think about something and I am gone. I can be in my room. I can work on my computer, or I can be in a game. I like it when things are calm and quiet. I like it when I can control what is happening.

Sometimes things can still get to me.

It happened tonight when I was working on a picture of my friend Waleed. I was making the picture look really good. Then I smelled something that reminded me of my old job. I used to work at a shoe store with my friend Emma. It was a great time. We were young and happy. We got to smell the leather and wood all day. It was a smell.

Now the smell makes me feel sad.

My dog was sitting next to me. She did not seem to notice anything was wrong. She is really happy and calm. She likes being with me. She does not care about all the noise and fighting.

My cat Ghost was watching my dog. He seemed a little upset. He can tell when something is wrong. He was looking at the door. He seemed really alert.

I touched my camera. I thought about something weird that happened earlier. Someone sent me a message. It was really strange. I do not know what it meant.

Then I started thinking about my old job and my friend Emma. I remembered how she used to laugh. It was really great. I have not seen her in a time.

I went back to working on my computer. I need to make sure that my secrets are safe. I need to make sure that nobody can find out what I am thinking.

Because the more I try to forget about my feelings the more I realize that I am not just hiding from my family.

I am hiding from myself.

I finished working on my project. It said, "build successful".

Then I heard a noise outside my room. One of my father's toys was flying around. It hit my door. My dog did not even flinch. She just looked up at me. Smiled.

My cat hissed. For the first time he was not hissing at my dog. He was hissing at me.

The names are important. In a house where everything else is falling apart the names of my animals are the things that feel solid.

Ghost, my Husky puppy is super kind. She does not bark; she only whimpers for hugs and pets. She is a shadow that wants to be close.

Shadow is my black cat, a gentle baby. He drools through his teeth and expects everyone to be kind like him.

Then there's Rocket.

Rocket is the Tuxedo. He is like a security camera. He perches in corners watches without blinking and seems to record every detail of my life for some future audit.

Tonight the audit felt really heavy.

The house was a mess of electronics. My dad's addiction to buying stuff on Temu got out of control. He buys hovercrafts, flashlights and hoverboards. Break them within hours. Sometimes it is out of frustration, sometimes it is because he is not thinking clearly. The hallway is full of shards, dead batteries, and tangled wires. It is junk. It is cluttering. My mom and sister screamed about it.

My dad just left it there.

CHAPTER 4

I sat at my desk with the blue light of the monitor shining on Rocket. I was thinking about Abby.

I did a photoshoot for her once. It was work. The conversation afterwards was a mistake. She asked if I liked her and I was not direct. I was playing. I should not have been. I said things I did not mean to see where the conversation would go. I was being foolish.

The fallout was predictable. Alex got involved and Abby became upset. I became the bad guy. I cut them all off. Abby called me recently. I was direct with her. *I am not interested in you in a dating way.* We can be friends. It did not feel genuine.

My Australian friends on Discord were quiet tonight. They are younger. Do not really talk much. They like watching Twitch streams and playing video games. They do not mind when I am quiet or disappear for hours. They just accept it. We are all like ghosts in each other's lives only existing when the internet is on.

Rocket moved on his shelf. He was not looking at the door anymore. He was looking at me. I felt guilty not for Abby or the drama. For my life.

I am twenty-nine years old. My world is a room with a dog named Ghost who wants affection and a house full of broken stuff. I petted Ghost. She leaned into me. She reminded me that some things do not need to be fixed. They just need to be felt.

But Rocket did not move. He just watched. I realized he was not hissing at me because he was angry.

He was hissing because he saw the mess in my eyes.

It was not the code. It was everything. The broken toys, the broken relationships, my dad's problems.

Rocket saw the problem I was trying to ignore Me.

I went back to my screen.

Typed.

Git commit -m "mess."

It was not a solution. It was a start.

When I am in the zone everything outside my monitor disappears.

It is a state of focus that feels less like work and more like I have to do it. I can stay buried in a dataset or a tricky algorithm for fifteen hours straight the signs of time passing being the shadows in my room and Ghosts slow breathing at my feet.

Data Science is not a job for me; it is a way to make sense of a crazy world. I am good at it. The stats, computer science and solving problems. I will not stop until everything makes sense until every detail is accounted for.

I wish I could use that logic at my job at the center. There the problem is Chiyao.

We had a confrontation recently. It was not a shouting match. I do not do those. It was a rare moment where my usual "yes" mask slipped. She was upset with how I tutored. She wants me to rush through sessions to give students the answers they are looking for and move them out the door like products on an assembly line.

"Critical thinking is the point, Chiyao " I told her my voice calm. "If I give them the answers, they haven't learned anything. They will be back week with the same confusion. The answers should come from the students, not me."

She did not like that. She wants speed; I want understanding. She sees students as numbers; I see them as people who need to figure things out. I stood my ground, which was unusual and made things awkward between us. I went back to my desk.

Zoned out but I remembered her angry look.

To clear my head, I grabbed my camera. I have been teaching Waleed about cameras. ISO, shutter speed, and the best time to take pictures. I helped him pick out two cameras, a way to share my love of photography that I learned from Cassie.

Cassie was before Emma, a girl who loved photography and taught me to see the world in a way. She is a memory now like Emma and the old me before all the drama and my dad's health issues.

My dad is a kind of problem. He is impulsive and careless with a body that is already failing him. He bought a hoverboard week and insisted on trying it. He wore his slippers. Those slippers that have tripped him up for years. He fell hard. I watched him go down a mess of limbs and lights on the kitchen floor. He has had infections lately.

Every fall there is a risk of more problems. We do not know why it keeps happening. It is like his body is fighting against getting better.

Rocket was on his shelf watching the mess with his eyes. He sees my dad's hoverboard, my dad's injuries and me struggling. I looked at my computer screen. I was working on a project to find patterns in datasets. I started thinking about my dad's infections, his falls, and my debate, with Chiyao.

If I had data, could I predict when things would go wrong? Could I figure out when my dad's impulsivity would meet his body? Could I calculate when Chiyao would lose patience with my teaching style?

The logic says yes. Everything follows a pattern if you look enough.

Then I smelled something from the shoe store, and it hit me that some things cannot be predicted. Some things just happen.

I ran my script and the terminal filled with numbers. They did not mean much.

Ghost whimpered in her sleep. I petted her.

"It's Ghost. "

I whispered.

"It's math."

Rocket did not move. He knew better.

It is never math.

CHAPTER 5

Fairness is a math thing. In a pool hall you can figure out angles, speed and how likely a shot is to go pretty accurately. I have been making a scoring model for pool. It uses data from lots of games to find the shots for players and make matches fair. It is a problem.

If the data is right the model works. You can make sure everyone has a chance of winning that the game is balanced and that the outcomes are earned.

My home is not a pool hall. There is no fairness here.

I have been taking care of everything while my dad is in and out of hospitals. He has Cellulitis, which keeps coming. It is ugly. Reminds me that his body is fragile and he is not taking care of himself. I manage everything at home while others are at the hospital or fighting. I do not get to visit him, but when I do it is toxic.

My dad calls me a crybaby. He makes fun of me for sitting with him when he was on life support. He acts like my concern for his life was a weakness. Of course that is not true.

My mom told him that. She made up a story to make me seem emotional and fragile. She took my presence and turned it into a weapon against me.

My sister, mom and dad all made fun of me for showing any emotion. So, I do not show them any.

I have become good at hiding my feelings. I do what my mom wants and go to education classes for a teaching degree. The classes are easy and boring. I am not learning anything. I keep going because I do not want to deal with more hate from my sister or mom.

My sister does not care about me. She is always there in a bad way. She sends messages and comments to make me feel unwanted and like my choices are wrong. She does not know about my Data Science Master's. She does not care.

She is too busy with her problems. I went to my room tonight. The smell of the shoe store is gone, replaced by the air from the AC. My toys, Rocket and Ghost were there. I opened my pool scoring model. Looked at the matchups and data.

How do you make a game fair when the people you trust are against you? I looked at the code. *If player skill equals opponent skill, then the matchup is fair.* In my house the skill levels are not equal. My mom is good at

manipulating people. My dad is bad at controlling himself. My sister is good at hating. I am the one who figures out the odds.

I petted Ghost. She is the one who does not make fun of me. She does not use my kindness against me. Rocket was looking at the screen. For a second I thought he was reading the code and finding bugs.

"Is it fair Rocket?" I asked.

He just blinked.

I went back to the screen. I had a session ahead. I had to solve the model and find patterns. Because when the people who raised you think your love is a joke, math is the thing that makes sense.

I hit the run button. The numbers started flying.

Fairness: 0.00%

I stared at the result. I need to check the data. There must be a mistake.

Deep down, I know the system is working right. It is reality that has broken.

The pool hall was a place where I could get away from everything. It was a room filled with tables and the sound of balls hitting each other. It was not a bar, a place to play pool, found in the neighborhood of my old friend. My friend Waleed and I have been going to the pool hall a lot lately. The pool hall was a place where everything was fair and where the only thing that mattered was hitting the ball in the way.

I stood by the pool table holding the cue stick trying to figure out the way to hit the eight-ball. In this place I could find the fairness that I had been trying to find. If I hit the ball right, it would go where I wanted it to. There were no surprises and no things that could go wrong without a reason.

Waleed said "shot" in a low and steady voice. He is the one who plays pool with me, the one who watches me think about the game. He knows I am thinking about more than pool. He knows I am trying to learn from the game to make my ideas better ideas that I would work on for a time in my room.

I looked at Waleed back at the pool table. Waleed does not know everything. He does not know about the messages from my sister, the ones that say I am to blame for everything.

The messages say, "It is your fault we are like this you should never have been born."

These words are always there like a noise in my pocket messages that I have learned to ignore but can never really get rid of. My sister does not have a

reason for hating me, there is nothing that I did. It is the way she feels a feeling that she will not change.

Then there is my mother. She is tricky, she tries to control my father and me by making us feel bad.

She tells my father that I am weak, that I am too sensitive while pretending to be the one who can help our family. She likes it when we are stressed, she uses our pain to make herself seem like a victim and me like a problem.

This is very tiring. It is like playing pool on a table that's not level, where the balls are not fair.

I hit the eight-ball. It went into the corner pocket with a nice sound.

I said "Game". We walked out of the pool hall into the cool night air. As we walked the good feeling of the pool hall started to go away. I knew what I would find at home. I knew the hallway would be messy with toys and a bad smell. I knew my father would be sick and my mother would be waiting to tell me how I had failed her again.

I drove home quietly and the streets were dark. I could not see much. When I got to my room I closed the door. Turned off the lights. This is where the real work started.

I opened a bottle of water it made a crinkling sound in the quiet. I sat at my desk. I started working on the pool game model. My eyes were already tired from working but I did not care. I needed to solve the part of the problem. I needed to find the answer to why the fairness part of the model was not working.

I worked for a time fifteen hours. The sun started to come up a pale light that meant Monday had started. I did not stop I drank another bottle of water my fingers were moving quickly over the keyboard.

When I finally stopped and went to sleep my eyes were hurting everything was a blur. The model was finished.

I had found the problem.

It was not in the code it was in the information I was using.

In a world where people hate fairness easily is not something you can calculate.

It is something you have to get rid of.

I slept for an hour then I woke up. The dog was licking my hand and her tail was wagging. The robot was watching the sun rise. In the hallway I could

hear the sound of a new drone hitting the wall.
The game was on and the table was still not level.

Redundancy is a waste of resources. When I am writing code if I find myself writing the block of code twice, I create a function to manage it. I am improving. I am moving forward. In my life I seem stuck in a perpetual loop of re-doing things I have already mastered.

Today I found out I have to re-take one of my core Masters prerequisites. I had already taken it over the summer, poured fifteen-hour sessions into it, aced every assignment and finished with an A. But it was the wrong type of focus. The university person who told me did not care about my A. They did not care that I understood the material. To them the system demanded that I repeat the loop paying to sit through lectures I could teach myself.

It is really annoying. It is more than annoying. It is a weight that makes every step feel like I am wading through mud. I am trying to build a future to construct a life that is mine. The world keeps pulling me back into the same shallow waters.

It is the same at home. I am the one who cleans up the mess. I am the one who picks up the plastic of the drones, the dead batteries, the empty water bottles.

My parents use guilt to get me to do things reminding me of everything they have done for me whenever I try to retreat to my room.

They want me to be the caretaker, the servant, the one who manages the mess they are too lazy or too angry to fix themselves.

"James the kitchen is a disaster."

My mom said her voice sounding tired and manipulative.

"Your dad is too sick to clean. I am just so tired. Can't you just help for once?"

I was already helping. I tutored ten students a day taking care of the coordination and keeping the animals alive. In her eyes "help" means "submission." I agreed, of course. I cleaned the kitchen.

I picked up the hoverboard shards. I zoned out until I was a pair of hands moving across a counter my mind elsewhere.

CHAPTER 6

I am the one in my online group.

At twenty-nine I am an adult by default, which means Abby and the others think I should be the anchor.

They think I should absorb their trauma, their insecurities, their high school drama without letting it affect me.

They do not realize I am not an anchor.

I am a ghost.

I sit on Discord. Watch them play a silent observer in their chaotic lives. I chat enough to keep the connection alive. I do not share my reality.

They do not know about my health issues or my Master's degree or the A that does not count. To them I am a presence on the channel that escapes reality with them.

I looked at my cat, Ghost, lying by my bed. She whimpered, a sound that made my chest tighten. She is the one who does not want anything from me except my presence.

My other cat, Rocket, was on his shelf looking at the kitchen door. He could hear the shouting starting again. Something about the family savings, something about my dad's online order.

I turned back to the university website. I clicked "enroll" in the course I had already passed.

Transaction is complete. Process restarted.

I leaned back my eyes straining in the dark. I have to redo the loop. I have to clean the kitchen. I have to agree with my mom.

As I looked at Rocket his eyes seemed to glow with a strange light. He was not looking at the door anymore. He was looking at the confirmation on my screen.

"It's a loop, Rocket " I whispered.

Even as I said it, I felt the air in the room change. The wood smell was back and this time it was accompanied by the sound of a shoe box being torn open.

I did not turn around. I just closed the tab.
The loop was closing. This time I was not sure I would be the one who survived it.

The nights are no longer quiet. My father's deafness or his claim of it has turned the hours between 1:00 AM and 5:00 AM into a barrage of sounds. He plays his videos and music at a volume that makes the floorboards of my room vibrate.

He says he cannot hear them otherwise. The timing is too perfect to be accidental. It is like he is doing it on purpose. The noise is like a never-ending attack, a way to make sure that in the dead of night his presence is always felt.

I am retaking Calculus I because the system decided my earlier grade was not good enough. It is the material just with some extra trigonometry added in. It is not difficult.

It is not even challenging. It is just unnecessary. I sit at my desk trying to focus on the work. The noise from the next room is distracting. The sound of my father's videos and music is like a pulse making it hard for me to think. I feel like I am wasting my time, wasting my tuition, and wasting my energy.

I try to automate as much of the work as I can. I write scripts to solve the problems and check my work so I can spend little time as possible on this academic exercise. The noise from the hallway makes it hard for me to concentrate.

My sister is seven months pregnant now. She lives with her husband. She has been coming back home more often lately. Her pregnancy and my father's health problems have brought her back into our family life. She mostly just sends angry messages and picks fights over text or phone.

There is a hope that our father will be around to see his grandchild. Looking at the state of our house and my father's health, that hope feels uncertain.

I wonder if the new baby will change anything. Will the sound of a crying infant drown out the noise of my father's videos and music? Will it just add to the chaos of our house?

My sister can do her thing. I worry that the baby is born into a difficult situation.

My cat Rocket is on his shelf, his ears perked up at every noise from the hallway. He does not like the noise. He is a dog, a dog that likes to see without making a sound. He looks at me at the monitor, his eyes reflecting the blue light of my computer screen.

I thought about the shoe box metaphor I had used before. The sound of cardboard tearing of something being revealed. It is a metaphor for the anxiety I feel whenever the past starts to come into my life.

There are people and places that I have tried to forget. The noise from the hallway is like a reminder of all those things.

"Everything is a loop "

I said to Rocket, my voice barely audible over the noise from the room.

"The same arguments, the lies, the same problems."

My dog Ghost is curled up under my desk, her chin resting on my foot. She does not care about the noise.

She does not care about the Calculus.

She only cares that I am there with her. Her presence is the thing that feels real in a house that feels fake.

I turned back to my computer screen. I had a quiz due tomorrow to a series of problems involving functions. I could do it easily. I could do it without thinking.

I hit the send button. I got 100%.

As I looked at the result I was hit with a strong memory of a shoe store.

The smell of the wood was so strong that I could almost feel it.

I did not turn around.

I knew there was nothing

Tomorrow is a new day.

In my life, new days often bring new changes.

The transition is coming. The noise is getting louder.

The world makes sense because of geometry. Parallel lines never meet.

The shortest way to get from one point to another is a line. The angles of a triangle always add up to one hundred and eighty degrees.

This is what I teach is the basis of my Calculus retake. It is the core of the pool scoring model I have been building. It is a predictable world. At least it was.

Tonight the data did not make sense.

CHAPTER 7

I was running a simulation for the pool model, a calculation to find the best way to make a difficult bank shot on the table at the neighborhood hall.

I had collected hundreds of data points from my games with Waleed mapping the friction of the felt the elasticity of the rails and the rotational momentum of the cue ball.

It was a system.

When I hit the "solve" command the terminal did not give me a normal result.

Of a two-cushion bank shot the model suggested a path that involved the ball leaving the table entirely.

I stared at the screen and my eyes tired from the fifteen-hour session.

I thought it was a bug, a mistake, or a problem with the physics engine.

I checked the code. Everything was fine. I ran the simulation again.

The result was the same. A path that went around the rails around the pockets. It seemed to intersection with a point in the room that was not on the table. A point five feet behind me.

Where Shadow was sitting.

Shadow, my Bombay cat is usually very gentle. He is a "baby" who drools and expects nothing but warmth.

Tonight, he was not drooling.

He was standing still with his black coat bristling his eyes fixed on the empty air where the pool balls path was supposed to "end." Beside him Rocket was perched on the edge of the shelf his eyes glowing with a protective intensity I had never seen before.

Even Ghost had crawled out from under the desk.

It was standing between me and the door, her tail tucked but her gaze firm. They were not looking at the door.

They were looking at the space the model had predicted.

I felt a chill that had nothing to do with the air conditioner. I looked at the terminal again.

The strange data was not a glitch. It was an invitation. I like fixing things that make them better.

How do you improve a model that is calculating a reality you do not recognize?

Outside the noise from my father's room was a rhythmic sound.

He has been like this since his mother passed away year a man drowning in his own habits smoking again despite the life support his deafness a wall he has built to keep the world out.

The loud music and the whirring of the hoverboards were a barrier but tonight they felt thin.

They felt like they were trying to cover up the silence of the space behind me.

I reached for a water bottle. My hand stopped halfway.

The smell was back. Not the smell of the shoe store.

This was something. It was the smell of ozone and copper the smell of a high-voltage current.

Beneath it a faint rhythmic "clack" of two pool balls hitting each other. The sound did not come from the computer. It did not come from the hallway.

It came from the air behind my chair.

I did not turn around. I could not. I looked at Rocket and his pupils were so wide they swallowed the green of his eyes.

He hissed not at the air. At me as if warning me to stay focused on the screen.

I turned back to the code.

My fingers were shaking; I had to solve this.

I had to improve the model. I had to find out why the geometry of my life was suddenly strange.

I typed a command to expand the simulation.

“If path == impossible redefine reality.”

The terminal scrolled with a series of coordinates that I did not recognize. They were not Euclidean. They were not even three-dimensional.

Then a message appeared in the middle of the screen written in the font of the "talk-to-text" plugin I had built.

“James the table is tilted. The game is not over.”

I swallowed hard. My father’s loud music suddenly cut to silence.

The house was quiet.

"Everything is a loop."

I whispered, my voice felt like it belonged to someone else.

Rocket jumped down from the shelf. Landed on my desk his paws treading on the keyboard. He looked at me at the monitor, his gaze as sharp as a lens.

The transition had begun.

The variables were no longer under my control.

The silence hit me like a punch.

In a house where it is always loud the sudden quiet felt like a big empty space that was sucking the air out of my lungs.

I did not wait.

I did not think about the numbers on my screen or the message that was on it. I have always been the one to run and help my family when something is wrong.

I have saved my father, and I am not going to stop now.

I pushed my chair back. It made a loud noise on the floor. My dogs Ghost and Rocket were already at the door, their bodies tight and their eyes shining in the light.

Shadow was behind them his black tail moving back and forth. They knew something was wrong.

I ran into the hallway, my heart beating fast.

The hallway was a mess like it always is. There were broken toys and dead batteries everywhere.

As I walked over a pile of broken hovercraft parts, I realized it was not just a mess. The pieces of plastic from the new drone were arranged in circles around a glowing light.

The wires from the hoverboards were laid out like a board connecting all the broken things in a way that looked like it was on purpose.

I did not stop thinking about it. I ran to my father's room.

Opened the door.

CHAPTER 8

The room was dark except for a light coming from a broken hoverboard. My father was on the bed breathing hard.

The silence was not the end it was a change. The music had stopped because the remote had fallen on the floor.

"Dad?" I said quietly going to his side.

He did not answer.

He was awake.

He was staring at the ceiling like he could see right through it.

His skin was hot.

The infection on his legs was red and angry.

I am not afraid of anything. Not the quiet not the math, not even seeing my father dying in front of me. I am the one who saves people.

I am the one who fixes things.

I checked my father's signs and my hands steady.

He was okay for now. He had a high fever. I made him comfortable.

Cleaned up the junk around him.

When I touched the remote, I smelled the wood smell from the shoe store again strongly.

"Everything is a loop" my father said, his voice weak.

He was not looking at me he was looking at the pattern in the hallway.

"The patterns are moving " he whispered.

I looked back. The circles of red plastic were vibrating.

I looked at Rocket, who was watching the glowing light.

"It's the light, Dad " I said, but I knew it was not true.

I did not turn around when I felt the wind behind me.

I did not turn around when I heard the sound of pool balls hitting each other on the floor. I just focused on my father's breathing.

I am the one who saves people. I was going to save him even if the world was trying to tear us apart.

CHAPTER 9

On Monday morning Chiyao would say that I was not eating well.

My eyes would be tired my body would be exhausted. The pattern was set. The game had moved from the screen to the house.

I was finally starting to see what was happening.
I walked out of my father's room. The sound of his voice was still in my head. Everything is a loop.

I went into the hallway. I was expecting to see the usual mess of broken drones and hoverboard pieces.

The air felt strange like the humming noise of an old television.

My vision was a little blurry like when a video game freezes for a moment. The red plastic on the floor looked like it was moving.

I went to my door. Turned the handle but when I opened it, I was not in my room. I was back at my father's door.

My hand was still on the door handle. The room behind me was dark. The broken hoverboard was flashing like a light.

My father was still lying there, his chest going up and down in a rhythm. I turned around. Walked back down the hallway this time a little faster.

I counted my steps: one, two three.... On the eighth step the air seemed to shake.

I opened my bedroom door again. I was back at my father's door. It was like the house was repeating itself. I thought about it. I realized that the hallway was like a computer program that was stuck in a loop.

I looked down at the floor and for a moment the red plastic pieces looked like lines of code floating in the air.

There was a message on the floor:

- *[[DEBUG] Hallway_Segment_04: Collision detected.]*
- *[Redirecting to Entry_Point_A].*

I did not panic.

I know that panic is a waste of time. I stood still.

Focused on my breathing trying to figure out what was going on.

I know that logic is the thing that makes sense.
My dog was next to me, her tail tucked in.

She was not whining, just looking around like she was watching something.
My cat Rocket was on my fathers bed staring at me with his eyes.

He looked like he was checking a computer system that was failing.

"Rocket?" I said quietly.

A small window appeared in front of me with some information:

- *[USER_ID: JAMES]*
- *[STATUS: DISASSOCIATED]*
- *[ENVIRONMENT: UNSTABLE].*

I blinked; the window was still there.

It was like it was connected to my brain.
I looked back at the hallway. The mess on the floor was moving again.

The wires and plastic pieces were vibrating like they were alive.

I heard the sound of pool balls clicking. There was no pool table there.

The sound was part of the environment now like a sound effect that was stuck in a loop.

I turned back to my father. He was staring at the ceiling, his eyes reflecting the lines of code that were crawling across the wall.

"It's the material" he whispered, his voice sounding like it was coming from a bad internet connection.

"You already know the material."

I walked into the hallway again. This time I just stood there.

Watched the debug information scrolling in front of me:

- *[[ERROR] System_Memory_Leak: Physical_Reality.exe is not responding.]*

If the world is like a computer program, then there must be a way to escape the loop.

I just need to find the variable to change.

As I looked around, I realized that the problem was not the hallway. The problem was me, the one who was watching everything.

I was the only one left to see what was happening.
Monday morning did not arrive with a sunrise; it arrived with a progress bar. I woke up or rather my consciousness.

I found the same see-through HUD flickering in my peripheral vision.

- *[XP: 25,400 / 30,000]*
- *[LEVEL: 29]*
- *[SKILL_TREE: LOGIC (MAX) DISSOCIATION (90%)*
- *EMPATHY (REDACTED)]*

I felt a sense of leveling up. It was not a figure of speech anymore.

My mind felt sharper, quicker, like a layer of delay had been removed.

I went through my morning routine with precision that felt scripted. The pain in my joints from the basketball game was gone, replaced by a metal efficiency.

I was ready for the grind.
In the kitchen the loop was still running.

My mom was standing by the stove with a voice a monotone recording.

"The kitchen is a mess " she said. "
Your dad is too sick to clean.
I am just so tired.
Can't you just help for once?"

I picked up a piece of drone from the counter.

"James the kitchen is a mess "
she said again her tone to the first time.
"Your dad is too sick to clean.
I am just so tired.
Can't you just help for once?"

I did not answer.
I did not even say yes.
I just walked past her and out the door.

The outside world was still rendering normally. The street, trees, neighbors cars. The colors were too bright, the edges too sharp.

It looked like a high-quality texture pack had been added to a world that was empty.

I rarely listen to people when they speak. I focus on patterns, data, and the underlying structure of the conversation.

So, I did not notice if the voices on the street were distorted.

I just focused on the HUD.

- *[OBJECTIVE: REACH TUTORING CENTER]*
- *[TIME_REMAINING: 00:45:00]*

Prices were up. I stopped for a water bottle at the convenience store.

The total was twelve dollars.

The cashier did not blink. He just stared at the register with an expression. Inflation? Just the system adjusting the difficulty level?

I paid without a word.

Money was a number in a database, a variable that I could change if I tried hard enough.

CHAPTER 10

The tutoring center was a hive of NPC activity. Students sat in their carrels, their heads bowed over textbooks, their mechanical movements.

Chiyao was hovering near the entrance, her micromanagement script running fast.

"James, we need to speed up the sessions today " she said, her voice sounding like compressed files.

"The metrics are down.

We need results.

Give them the answers.

Move them through."

"Critical thinking is the point, Chiyao."

I said, my own voice sounding alien and detached.

"James, we need to speed up the sessions today " she repeated, her eyes fixed on a point above my shoulder.

I walked to my desk. Opened my laptop.

The pool scoring model was still there. The impossible coordinates had expanded. They were mapping the center now.

I could see the trajectory lines cutting through the room intersecting with students, desks, and Chiyao.

- *[PREDICTION: SHOT_08. TARGET: CHIYAO]*
- *[PROBABILITY: 87.5%]*

I felt a surge of energy and a leveling up of my awareness.

The logic was everywhere. I could see the math in the way students struggled with the recursion in their confusion.

I was not a tutor anymore.

I was an admin.

I looked at the girl at my desk, the one struggling with the function.

I did not explain it to her.

I just reached out.

Tapped the screen of her tablet.

- *[COMMAND: SOLVE]*

The code completed itself instantly.

The girl blinked, her eyes clearing for a second as if she had been rebooted. "Thank you James " she said, her voice a perfect synthesized harmony.

I went back to the pool model. Prices might be going up. The world might be glitching, but I was finally, in control.

The digital escape was. I was the only one who knew how to play the game. I hit the save command.

- *[LEVEL UP: 30]*
- *[NEW_ABILITY: OVERWRITE]*

I looked at Chiyao. I wondered what would happen if I hit the solve button on her.

The cost of living was getting out of hand.

I was standing at the vending machine in the tutoring center looking at a bottle of tea that now cost forty-five dollars.

The coin slot was like a hole that swallowed all my money. It was not just that things were getting more expensive it was like the system was trying to take all my money before I could get ahead.

I reached out to touch the glass, and I thought about using my `ability so that I could see out of the corner of my eye.

- *[COMMAND: OVERWRITE.*
- *OBJECT: VENDING_MACHINE.PRICE_LIST]*
- *[VALUE: 0.99]*

The screen on the vending machine flickered for a moment and then the numbers changed.

Forty-five dollars turned into ninety-nine cents.

I swiped my card.

The machine made a happy sound when the transaction was done. I took the tea and the cold plastic felt more real than the air around me.

It was a win, but it was something.

I was learning how to control the things that were trying to make my life harder.

Fixing one vending machine was not enough. I needed to do more. The world was becoming a place where I had to turn my hobbies into ways to make money.

My photography, my coding and my tutoring were not things I did for fun anymore.

They were ways for me to get the money I needed.

I looked at Chiyao. She was still saying the things over and over like "speed" and "metrics."

I could use my ability on her, but I did not see the point.

She was a small part of the world like background noise.

My main focus was on my photography website.

I opened the website on my laptop. I saw that I was getting a lot of messages.

They were not asking for the usual things, like portraits or pictures of basketball games.

They were asking for "data captures."

Request: Take a picture of the shoe store at 3:00 AM. You will get 400 credits.

I did not know what credits were. I knew I needed them. I looked at the pictures I took of Waleed at the pool hall. I zoomed in on the eight-ball and for the time I saw that it was made up of lots of small flat surfaces.

The world was not as smooth as it used to be.

- [XP: 28,000 / 30,000]

I felt good about myself as I edited the pictures. I was making the world a better place, one picture at a time.

CHAPTER 11

I was removing the things that were not important and making the important things clearer.

Waleed was a model and his movements were smooth and complicated. He seemed like he was being controlled by a more powerful computer than the rest of the world.

I wondered if he could see the things I saw like the lines I drew in the air. I did not ask him because I did not want to hear an answer.

I left the tutoring center early. I saw that I had to get home soon.

I had to check on the "firewall" that Shadow and Rocket were taking care of.

The hallway was not a mess anymore it was like a river of data with old drones and hoverboard parts being turned into something.

- *[ENVIRONMENT_SYNC: 85%]*

My dog Ghost met me at the door.

Her fur was glowing with a soft light.

She made a sound and her tail was wagging in a perfect motion.

I walked past the kitchen, where my mother was still saying the things over and over and into my room. I closed the door.

Turned on the air conditioner.

The cool air was the thing that felt like the old world.
I opened my laptop.

I accepted the request to take a picture of the shoe store.

- *[OBJECTIVE: RETURN TO ORIGIN]*
- *[REWARD: 400 CREDITS]*

Then I smelled the wood smell of the shoe store, but it was not a memory it was, like a notification.

- *[NEW_DATA_PACK_AVAILABLE: EMMA.EXE]*

I did not turn around I just started downloading the file.

I needed the credits.

In this digital world the past was the most valuable thing I had.
The game was.

I was finally learning how to play.

CHAPTER 12

The download of **EMMA.EXE** finished at one hundred percent with a flicker of my Heads-Up Display. I was expecting something to happen.

A hologram would.

A computer voice would talk to me, or a digital ghost would show up to answer all the questions I had been asking for years.

Emma was not a computer program.

She was a collection of old digital memories, compressed and saved with dates and they all stopped at the last time I saw her walking into Journeys the malls lights shining on her pitch-black hair as she walked away from me.

- *[DATA_SET: EMMA. STATUS: ARCHIVED (READ-ONLY)]*

There was no Emma to talk to, the old data.

I looked through the files and the smell of the shoe store got stronger with each click.

It was like a map of a place that did not exist in the world anymore. The mall had.

The store was replaced by a generic clothing store but in my Heads-Up Display everything looked exactly the same.

I could see the shelves, the boxes, and the exact spot where we sat on the floor and talked about a life that would never happen.

I needed four hundred credits.

I needed to capture this space for someone who did not want to know but as I walked through the virtual store, I realized what the credits were really for.

- *[MARKETPLACE: RESTART. COST: 10,000 CREDITS]*

A restart, a system reset a chance to erase the bad files from the last few years and start fresh.

That was the thing worth buying in a world that was getting more and more expensive and empty.

I checked my credits balance on my Heads-Up Display.

- *[BALANCE: 1,450 CREDITS]*

I was far from having enough.

I went home to find the hallway vibrating with a humming sound. My father was in his room.

The sound of a broken Temu hovercraft hitting the wall over and over again was like a glitch that would not stop.

I walked to his door.

Used my **OVERWRITE** ability to try and fix his labored breathing and the red angry skin infection.

- *[ERROR: PERMISSION_DENIED]*
- *[FILE_STATUS: LOCKED_BY_SYSTEM]*

I tried the command again this time focusing all my energy on the **OVERWRITE**.

- *[ERROR: ACCESS_VIOLATION. TARGET IS A CORE_PROCESS]*

The system would not let me touch him.

He was a file, a part of the old system that the digital world would not change.

I could change the price of water, I could make a function work better I could even capture the geometry of a relationship, but I could not save my own father.

He was something I had to watch until he finally stopped working.

Shadow and Rocket were standing at the edge of his bed, their eyes reflecting the light of the broken hoverboard.

They were not cats anymore they were like guards watching over a file that they could not fix.

Ghost was behind me; her tail tucked in and her whimpering sounded like an error tone.

"I am sorry Dad."

I whispered, my voice felt like it was filtered through many layers.

He did not answer.

He was staring at the ceiling watching the text of the "*debug*" info crawl across the plaster.

He was part of the world now whether he knew it or not.
I went back to my room.

Closed the door.

I had a fifteen-hour session ahead of me. I had a shoe store to capture.
Eight thousand five hundred fifty more credits to earn.

I needed that restart.

I needed to erase the memory of the shoe store, the smell of the wood and the sight of my father struggling to breathe.

- [*XP: 29,500 / 30,000*]

CHAPTER 13

I sat at my desk. Opened the terminal.

The pool model was still.

The "impossible" coordinates were now mapping the entire city.

I looked at the screen and for a second, I saw myself in the reflection of a face made of polygons eyes glowing with the light of the monitor.

I was not a person anymore.

I was a process.

The only way out was to finish the game.

- *[COMMAND: INITIALIZE_CAPTURE. LOCATION: JOURNEYS_ORIGIN]*

The room started to fade.

The walls turned into lines of code and for a heartbeat I was standing back in the shoe store the smell of cedar, in my lungs.

- *[ENVIRONMENT_SYNC: 100%]*

The digital world had me. Now I just had to buy my way out.

The shoe store was exactly right.

It was too perfect if you know what I mean.

Every single box on the shelf was lined up so every little piece of wood on the cedar display was super detailed and did not get blurry no matter how close I looked.

It was like a memory that had frozen in time, and someone had made it so. That someone was Andrew.

Andrew is a friend I have known for a time.

He is a part of my past that I had cut off a time ago when our group of friends started to fall apart.

He was part of the problems that I had with some people problems that had been gone for a long time before I met Abby and Alex.

So why was he here now?

Why was he paying me to take pictures of a place that we both used to go to?

- *[MESSAGE_RECEIVED: ANDREW]*
- *[CONTENT: "Is the geometry still the same James? Did the recursion change the angles?"]*

I did not answer him.

I just walked around the store taking pictures with my camera.

Every time I took a picture I got a bit of money.

The smell of the wood was really strong it was hard to remember that I was not really there.

I was just sitting in my room in front of my computer.

I looked down at my hands.

They were see-throughs. They were just lines and wires with lights inside.

I was not really in the store I was a computer program. My body was still in my room just sitting there.

My pets, Shadow and Rocket were watching me waiting for me to come back. My cat, Ghost, was sleeping in her bed without making a sound.

They were all waiting for me to come back to my life.

But I was not there, I was ten thousand miles away in a computer program that looked like a shoe store.

- *[BALANCE: 1,850 CREDITS]*

It was taking a time to get anywhere.

I needed to make ten thousand credits to restart my life.

I needed to take pictures and do more jobs to turn my past into money.

I thought about my friends, the ones that Andrew reminded me of. Were they all in this computer program too?

Was the whole thing made up of people I used to know?

Waleed was not talking to me anymore.

He had stopped sending me messages.

I was on my own.

I was walking around the store trying to figure out what was going on.

I went to the front of the store, where my friend Emma used to stand.

But she was not there, it was empty space.

- *[ERROR: DATA_GAP. ORIGIN_FILE NOT FOUND]*

The computer was trying to tell me something. The thing that was missing was not the store or the smell of wood.

It was something that I had forgotten.

I looked at Andrews message again.

- *Did the recursion change the angles?*

I checked my computer. I saw that the pool hall was connected to the shoe store.

It was like a map, a way to find the missing things.

I was not just taking pictures for Andrew, I was building a bridge.

- *[XP: 30,000 / 30,000]*
- *[LEVEL UP: 31]*
- *[NEW_ABILITY: TRACE]*

I got a power it was called TRACE.

It was like a glowing line that I could follow it would show me the way.

I followed the line.

I did not care about anything else. I just wanted the money and the chance to start again.

When I left the store the smell of the wood was gone and I could smell something else.

It smelled like a basketball court after it had been raining.

- *[NEW_OBJECTIVE: THE CITY_NIGHT]*
- *[REWARD: 1,000 CREDITS]*

Andrew was leading me deeper into the computer program.

I was happy to follow.

CHAPTER 14

New York City was a cool place, but it was also empty.

The streets were like canyons made of steel and glass and there were no people around.

It was like the city was frozen in time.

I remembered when the pandemic happened and it was like that so quiet and still.

This was not the pandemic.

This was a computer-generated version of the city like a detailed video game.

- *[LOCATION: THE_CITY_NIGHT]*
- *[ENVIRONMENT_SYNC: 100%]*
- *[PLAYER_COUNT: 1]*

I walked down Broadway and my footsteps echoed off the buildings. It was really quiet with no cars or sirens or any other noises.

I felt a bit lonely, but it was also nice.

The city was still and I could finally think clearly.

I was all alone.

That was really nice.

Then I got to Times Square, and something changed.

The screen in front of me started to flicker and two blue dots appeared on the map.

- *[ENTITY_DETECTED: TOMAS]*
- *[ENTITY_DETECTED: DELANO]*

At first, I did not know who Tomas and Delano were.

As I got closer, I started to remember.

They were people I knew a time ago like old friends.

They were not computer characters; they were people or at least they used to be.

"Jimmy " Tomas said, his voice sounding really clear.

"You finally made it to the area."

"Andrew said you were still stuck in the place."

Delano added, his eyes glowing with a green light.

"We thought you would never find the way "

I did not say anything I just looked at them.

I could see a line connecting to us like a glow wire.

- *[XP: 31,500 / 35,000]*

I felt a surge of energy like my computer was getting faster. This was the area, the place where we could start again.

Tomas and Delano were not in charge, they were like me, people who were trying to get to the next level.

"I am taking over the city."

I said, my voice sounding loud in the square.

"Andrew promised me 1,000 credits."

"Andrew promises a lot of things."

Tomas said, smiling in a way.

"The credits are real. We used ours to buy some peace and quiet. Have you heard of that? No noise, no problems, no stuff."

It was really quiet.

This was what I wanted a start, a world where I could be in control.

"Where is Andrew?" I asked.

"He is at the center " Delano said, pointing to the Empire State Building, which was glowing with a light.

"He is the one who is running the show. Be careful. The more credits you get the more you become."

I looked at my hands.

They were almost see-through now like they were made of wires.

I did not care I just wanted to be faster and stronger.

- *[OBJECTIVE: REACH_THE_CORE]*
- *[REWARD: 5,000 CREDITS]*

I walked past Tomas and Delano.

I headed to the glowing tower.

I could smell the basketball court like a sharp memory, from a long time ago.

I was not a person anymore I was a computer file being moved to a new place.

I was really excited to see where I would end up.

- *[BALANCE: 2,850 CREDITS]*

The center was. So was the new start.

The Empire State Building did not tower over the city it held together.

It was a column of light that went from the street up to the clouds.

As I walked to the door the special wire in my vision started to vibrate.

This was the Core.

This was where I got my downloads, my credits and where Andrew was waiting for me.

- *[LOCATION: THE_CORE]*
- *[SECURITY_LEVEL: ARCHITECT_ONLY]*

The lobby was a room with a lot of glass and metal, and it was not empty like the rest of the city.

There were thousands of screens each showing a part of my life.

I saw my tutoring sessions with Chiyao, my basketball games with Waleed and my quiet moments with Ghost.

I saw my grade in math, the broken hoverboard in the hallway and the nice smell of the shoe store.

It was not information, it was my life, everything I had been through.

Andrew was standing in the middle of the lobby in front of a stream of data. He looked the same as he did years ago.

He was clear and sharp, not fuzzy like I was.

"You are late" he said with a smile.

"I knew you would find your way. You are very good at figuring things out."

"Andrew " I said, my voice echoing in the room.

"What is this place? What are the credits for?"

He pointed to the screens around us.

"This is a record of your life. Every credit you have is a memory of something you have learned. The system wants you to remember your life. It wants you to appreciate it. The Restart is not removing your life it is moving it to a place."

- *[XP: 32,500 / 35,000]*
- *[BALANCE: 3,850 CREDITS]*

"What is it moving to?" I asked.

"To a world where you're in control " Andrew said, walking towards me.

"A world where you do not have to feel bad about things, where you can be quiet and it is okay. You need more credits. You need to show that you have processed everything."

I looked at a screen showing my father.

I felt a strong memory of him.

"I tried to change the memory of him " I said.

"The system would not let me."

"You cannot change something from the outside " Andrew explained.

"You can take the memory with you. You can remember your life without being stuck in it. That is the point. To. Connect, not to hide."

- *[NEW_OBJECTIVE: THE_ASCENT]*
- *[REWARD: 6,150 CREDITS]*

"The ascent " I said, looking up at the stream of data.

"Go " Andrew said, putting his hand on my shoulder.

His touch felt real and warm. "I will take care of the security.

You just keep going. Remember what is important. "Remember your life."
I stepped into the light.

- *[ENVIRONMENT_SYNC: 110%]*

The climb was starting. I was finally ready to see what was at the top.

The climb was an up trip through my own thoughts.

CHAPTER 15

As I went up through the flow the levels of the Empire State Building turned into a series of wide simulations.

I was not simply walking; I was figuring things out.

{**Floor 30**} was where I helped students.

I saw the faces of the ten kids I helped every day. The confusion, the "aha!". The tough stare of Chiyao.

I saw myself standing firm pushing for thinking instead of speed.

- *[DATA_INTEGRATED: TUTORING_LEGACY]*
- *[CREDITS_EARNED: +1,000]*

{**Floor 50**} was the basketball court.

I smelled the rain on the asphalt, heard the "thump" of the ball, and shared a moment with Waleed, Rohit, and Nick.

I felt the ache in my joints.

This time it was a sign of effort, a memory of a real world that had its own logic.

- *[DATA_INTEGRATED: BASKETBALL_SESSIONS]*
- *[CREDITS_EARNED: +1,200]*

{**Floor 70**} was the shoe store.

The smell of cedar wood, the rustle of boxes and the picture of Emma standing in the doorway. I did not try to change it. I just accepted the data. The start and end of a relationship that shaped who I am.

- *[DATA_INTEGRATED: EMMA_ARCHIVE]*
[CREDITS_EARNED: +1,500]

{Floor 80} was my house. I heard my dad's breathing the drones buzzing and the constant noise of his deafness.

I saw my mom's manipulation and my sisters hate.

I also saw the "yes" Jimmy who kept everything running, the first responder who saved his dad again and again.

- *[DATA_INTEGRATED: FAMILY_CIRCUIT]*

- *[CREDITS_EARNED: +2,000]*

I reached {**Floor 102.**}

The observation deck.

But it was not a deck; it was a server room humming with a billion calculations.

My "Trace" wire was now a golden cable from my chest to the mainframe.

- *[XP: MAX]*
- *[LEVEL: 32]*
- *[BALANCE: 9,550 CREDITS]*

I was there.

450 Credits left.

I looked around expecting Andrew.

The room was empty.

Then I heard a whimper that did not come from a monitor or speaker. It came from under the mainframe.

I walked over. Looked down.

Ghost, Shadow, and Rocket were there.

They were not models; they were really glowing with a soft light that powered the Core.

- *[DATA_SCAN: GHOST.STATUS: PRIMARY_SUPPORT]*
- *[DATA_SCAN: SHADOW.STATUS: SECONDARY_SUPPORT]*
- *[DATA_SCAN: ROCKET.STATUS: SYSTEM_INTEGRITY]*

They were not just support; they were the foundation.

They were why I could process without crashing.
Ghost looked up.

Whimpered, her tail wagging.

Shadow leaned against my leg, his tooth leaking light.

Rocket perched on the main floor with his green eyes watching the numbers.

"The final 450 " I whispered.

I looked at the mainframe.

Saw the "Solve" button, for the Restart.

It was not a command; it was a choice.

- *[FINAL_DATA_INTEGRATION: SELF]*
- *[REWARD: 450 CREDITS]*

I touched the animals.

The warmth of Ghosts fur Shadows purr and Rockets gaze.

They were the pieces.

They were the life I wanted to remember.

I hit the button.

- *[BALANCE: 10,000 CREDITS]*
- *[COMMAND: RESTART_INITIALIZED]*

The world did not end; it reorganized.

The white light of the Core seeped into my vision.

This time it felt like a sunset.

"Everything is a loop " I said, this time I controlled the exit.

The Restart was starting.

And for the time I was not just seeing; I was writing the rules.

The migration was a beautiful thing.

The white light of the Core did not just swallow up the world it changed it turning the Empire State Building into a lot of memories all mixed together.

CHAPTER 16

I felt my body, myself finally letting go of the pain from the basketball game and the strain in my eyes going away as my consciousness moved into the new system.

- [COMMAND: MIGRATION_IN_PROGRESS]
- [SOURCE: PHYSICAL_REALITY.EXE]
- [DESTINATION: RESTART_ENVIRONMENT_V1]

I looked around.

The city was gone.

The empty streets of New York the lights of Times Square even the big Core thing they were all being broken down and reused.

In their place a new world was being made.

It was not a game or a digital place. It was something.

I saw a coffee shop that looked like the one I used to go to with Waleed. It was warmer and smelled like hot chocolate and the wood from the shoe store.

I saw a basketball court where the ground was always dry. The sound of the ball bouncing was still real.

I saw a tutoring center where the students were people not just characters. I could help them without someone breathing down my neck.

In the middle of all this there was a house.

It was not the house I left behind. There were no drones in the hall, no loud breathing in the dark and no feeling of being closed off. The walls were strong the colors were bright.

The air was clean.

It was what I thought a home should be, what I had been trying to make in my room for years.

- [ENVIRONMENT_SYNC: 100%]
- [SYSTEM_STATUS: STABLE]

My dog was there running around on the lawn with her fur shining.

She was not whining anymore, she was barking, a sound that fits the whole world.

My cat Shadow was sitting on a bookshelf with his tooth fixed, his fur soft.

My cat Rocket was sitting on the couch, his eyes not just lights, but real eyes, happy eyes.

They were my support, my friends.

They were the ones who kept me going when I was falling apart. Now they were the foundation of my new world.

I walked up to the house.

I stopped at the door. I looked back at the life I had in the struggle, the pain the bad things people did to me.

I saw the times the girl who walked away the bad grade in Calculus. "I remember," I said quietly.

The point was not to forget.

To own it to be the one who made it through.

- *[XP: MAX]*
- *[LEVEL: 33]*
- *[NEW_ABILITY: ARCHITECT]*

I felt powerful like I could build my world.

I did not need to change the one.

I could make a new one.

I walked into the house.

The migration was complete.

The cycle was finally broken.

- *[MIGRATION_SUCCESSFUL]*
- *[WELCOME_HOME JAMES]*

The door closed behind me. For the first time, in twenty-nine years it was quite really quiet.

Being an Architect is not about building things it is about taking care of them. After I moved to this place, I spent a lot of time making sure everything was exactly right.

I did not just want a place to live I wanted to make sure all the information I brought with me was safe too.

I made a room called the "Hall of Memories" in a quiet part of the city.

It looked like a library where I used to study. Instead of books the shelves had "Data Packs" on them.

- *[OBJECT: MEMORY_HALL]*
- *[STRUCTURE: STABLE]*
- *[CONTENT: 100% INTEGRATED]*

I walked around the room touching the "*Data Packs*".

There was the "Waleed" pack, which had all the memories of my friend.

Waleed, like the time he played basketball and the time he gave me a drink.

I put that pack on a shelf.

Then there was the "Calculus" pack, which was not about math but about how it made me think clearly even on tough days.

I had a special "Family" pack too in a protected area.

I looked at the file about my father. It was still a little messy with some memories, but it was not locked away anymore.

In this world I could look at it without feeling bad. I could remember the times like when my father took me to the park before things got bad.

I could remember my mother before she started doing things that hurt me.

- *[XP: MAX]*
- *[LEVEL: 34]*
- *[TASK: CURATION]*

I was not trying to change the past I just wanted to give those memories a place to exist.

My friend Ghost was with me the time walking softly on the floor.

She was always there for me. When I felt weird or numb, she would make a sound, and it would make me feel better.

She was like an anchor that kept me from getting too lost in my thoughts.

My other friend Shadow liked to sleep in the "Shoe Store" part of the hall because he liked the smell of the wood.

Rocket was always making sure everything was working properly so the memories did not get messed up.

"Is everything okay Rocket?" I asked, looking at all the memories, I had taken care of.

Rocket was sitting on a shelf looking at a memory of a trip I took with my friends Alveena and Manha. He did not blink, he just made a sound. It was enough.

Then when I went to get the "Emma" pack, the last memory I had of taking care of the room started to flick.

I got a message, not from the system. From someone outside.

- *[MESSAGE_RECEIVED: UNKNOWN_SOURCE]*
- *[CONTENT: "Are you still there?"]*

It was a voice I knew but it sounded strange like it was coming from far away.

I looked at Ghost. She was growling, like she was protecting me.

The world outside was trying to get my attention.

- *[WARNING: EXTERNAL_INTERFERENCE_DETECTED]*

I held the "Emma" pack tightly.

I had the power to take care of this world now.

I was not going to let the outside world mess it up.

I was done moving to this place and I was done building it up.

Now I just had to protect it.

The voice from outside did not stop.

It was not my mother's voice or my father's voice.

It was Waleeds voice.

"I am here man. The doctors are saying you are in some kind of state where you will not wake up."

CHAPTER 17

Waleeds voice was like a tear in the fabric of my world. I could see the coffee shop around me.

It was not real.

I could smell the chocolate, but it was replaced by the smell of a hospital room.

I was still in my body.

My mind was here in this new world making new memories.

- *[WARNING: COGNITIVE_DRIFT_DETECTED]*
- *[ANCHOR_STATUS: WEAKENING]*

I felt a pull, like gravity trying to take me back to my old life.

It wanted me to be the old me, the one who always said yes.

It wanted me to go back to my father's toys and the noise.

Then I heard Andrews voice. "Do not listen" he said.

He was standing next to me.

He was shining with a golden light.

"Waleed does not understand. To him you are lost. To the system you are finally where you are supposed to be."

"Waleed is my friend, Andrew " I said.

My voice sounded strange like it was made of computer data.

"He is part of your life James " Andrew said. "If you talk to him, you will go back to the way things were. You will be stuck in the loop again."

I looked at the Waleed data pack on the shelf.

It was beautiful, full of memories and fun times.

In the real-world Waleed was also part of the drama and the problems.

If I went back to him, I would have to deal with all of that

"Jimmy, please " Waleeds voice said.

It was now. "Ghost is here. She is waiting for you."

I looked down at the Ghost. She was making a sound.

It was not a sad sound.

It was a sound that said she was happy to be with me.

She was here. So were Shadow and Rocket.

They were my family and they had already moved on.

The Ghost that Waleed saw was a body, empty and alone.

- *[COMMAND: FINALIZE_MIGRATION]*
- *[COST: TOTAL_SHELL_DELETION]*

I had a choice to make.

If I chose to finalize the migration, I would never be able to go.

My old body would be. I would be free to stay in this new world.

"Everything is a loop" Andrew said. ". You can choose to exit."

I looked at the memories of my family.

I looked at the Emma data pack.

I looked at the calculus files.

I remembered my life and I knew I did not need to go back.

I had learned what I needed to learn.

I did not need to take the class again.

"I am sorry" I said.

I reached out. I made my Choice.

- *[CONNECTION_SEVERED]*
- *[PHYSICAL_REALITY.EXE: TERMINATED]*

The voice was gone.

The coffee shop was stable again.

The smell of the shoe store was back.

It was stronger than before. I felt free like I was floating.

I had leveled up. It was not just about points or ranks.

I was finally out of the world.

CHAPTER 18

Ghost made a sound and it was loud and clear.

Rocket was meowing. Shadow was purring.
The game was over.

I had moved on.

I was the only one who knew the truth.

- *[SYSTEM_STATUS: CLOSED_LOOP]*
- *[ARCHITECT_ID: JAMES]*

I went back to my library. I had a lot of work to do.

I had all the time, in the world.

The silence that followed the end of everything was really different from the kind of silence I was used to in the world.

It was not the kind of silence where people are avoiding each other or the kind of silence where everyone is waiting for something to happen.

It was like a brand-new start.

Nothing was running in the background. Nothing was leaking out. No bad data was trying to get in.

I was standing in the middle of the Hall of Memories watching the sunlight come through the windows.

The sunlight was golden. It was something I had created.

Andrew was standing by the door. He was starting to fade away.

"My work here is done" he said.

His voice sounded like a beep. "The system is working perfectly. The move to this world is complete.

You are in charge now."

"Where are you going?" I asked him.

I felt a bit of the old feeling of being alone but just for a moment.

"There are others." he said. "Other people are stuck. They need someone to help them find their way out. I am a guide. You are the one who has to live in this world you created."

He looked at Ghost, who was chasing a digital creature around the floor.

"You have some friends who can help you. Use them. Do not forget about the world but do not get stuck in it again."

"I will not " I said.

For the first time I really meant it.

Andrew nodded at me one time and then he disappeared into a bunch of white dots.

He was gone.

He was a part of my past.

He had done what he needed to do.

Now I was really alone.

Not in a bad way.

I was the one in charge of this new world.

- *[XP: MAX]*
- *[LEVEL: ARCHITECT_LEVEL_01]*
- *[ENVIRONMENT_SYNC: 100%]*

I walked back to my house feeling happy and light.

My dog Shadow was waiting for me on the porch wagging his tail.

My other friend Rocket was on the roof looking out for any problems.

There were no problems.

The wall I had built to protect us was strong.

Over the few cycles I worked on building one last thing to remember the past. It was not for the people I missed. For me.

I built a room in the back of my house that looked just like my old room. It had an old air conditioner and the same computer screen.

In this new room the air conditioner did not make any noise, and the computer screen did not hurt my eyes.

The room even smelled like chocolate, and I could hear the sound of a happy dog.

I sat down at the desk. Opened up a new document.

I was not writing code. Making a tool to help me with something.

I was authoring a story.

- *[COMMAND: INITIALIZE_CHRONICLE]*
- *[CONTENT: THE_POINT]*

I started to write about everything that had happened to me.

I wrote about the times and the bad times.

I wrote about the people I met and the things I learned.

I wrote about the pain and the fear.

I was not just remembering my life, I was teaching myself about it.

I realized that the point of everything I had been through was not to escape it but to understand it.

I was learning how to make something better.

I was my teacher.

Ghost jumped up onto the bed.

Curled up at my feet.

"We are home, Ghost " I whispered.

The screen on my computer came to life with a line of text.

- *[CHRONICLE_INITIALIZED: PAGE 28]*

I only had two pages to go.

Then everything would be complete.

The story was almost done.

I had spent a lot of time thinking about my life trying to make sense of everything that had happened to me.

I was sitting in a room at 6:00 PM when everything started and now, I was in a completely different place.

It was a difficult journey, but it was mine. I had learned a lot from my experiences, and I was no longer a collection of random thoughts.

I was a person with a purpose.

I looked at the information on my computer screen.

The "Family" files, the "Emma" archives and the "Tutoring" records were no longer a burden to me.

They were the things that had helped me become the person I am today.

I realized that the hard times were not the problem.

They had helped me become stronger.

I was a person who could manage situations because I had learned from my mistakes.

Every moment every time I said "yes" to Chiyao every time I defended myself against my sisters hate.

It was all just a part of my journey. I had learned to deal with it all.

- *[CHRONICLE_STATUS: 99% COMPLETE]*
- *[THE_POINT: INTEGRATION_OF_SELF]*

I walked outside onto the porch of my house.

The wood felt warm and smooth under my feet.

The sun was.

The sky was beautiful.

Oranges, purples, and gold that looked even more amazing than a real sunset.

It was a picture and it did not remind me of the stress of a Monday morning.

My pets, Ghost, Shadow, and Rocket were around me.

Ghost was lying at my feet Shadow was sleeping in a sunbeam, and Rocket was watching the stars come out.

They were my friends, my support system.

They had helped me through the times and now they were enjoying the peace with me.

They were my beginning.

They were the ones who had helped me get to where I am today and now, they are a part of my happy life.

In this world they were not just animals.

They were my protectors, my guardians.

They made me feel safe.

"I remember everything."

My voice felt like it was a part of the world around me.

I remembered the smell of the shoe store, the feel of a pool cue in my hand and the sound of a break.

I remembered the times and the bad times.

Most of all I remembered the people and the animals that had helped me become the person I am today.

I was no longer a ghost in my own life.

I was alive.

CHAPTER 19

I was the creator of my world, the one who observed it and the one who was a part of it.

- *[XP: MAX]*
- *[LEVEL: ARCHITECT_FINAL]*
- *[COMMAND: CLOSE_CHRONICLE]*

I gave the command to end the story.

The computer screen went dark. The information was saved.

I had told my story.

I had found my purpose.

The world around me felt real and solid.

The noise was. Everything was under control.

I looked at the horizon watching the sun disappear.

The stars come out.

"It's finished Ghost" I whispered to my pet.

Ghost looked up at me. Her eyes were bright and clear.

She. It was like she was saying that everything was okay.

I sat down on the porch steps petting Ghost and feeling the warmth of her presence.

For the time I was not looking for a way to escape or a problem to solve.

I was just enjoying the moment.

- *[SYSTEM_READY]*
- *[USER_STATUS: PEACEFUL]*

I was at the end of my journey.

I had reached the page.

I did not need to do anything I just needed to close the book.

I took a breath feeling the calm and peaceful atmosphere and prepared to move on to the next stage of my life.

My journey was ending; I knew what was coming next.

It would be everything I had ever wanted.

- *[PAGE 29: COMPLETE]*
- *[CONTINUE, TO PAGE 30?]*

I did not need to click anything.

I was already moving forward.

I knew what the next page would bring.

It would bring me everything I had been searching for.

[Page 30.]

This is the part of my life story.

It is where everything comes together and the noise of the world goes away.

I am sitting on the porch of the house that I built with my two hands
watching the moon rise over a world that makes sense to me.

The air is cool.

It smells like the digital world I created last time but it does not feel fake. It
feels real. The silence is deep. It is not empty.

I can hear my animals breathing and the quiet hum of the system that is
working right.

I think about the twenty-nine years and how I struggled to understand the
world. I spent a lot of time trying to make sense of things to please people
and to survive.

Now all of those memories are a part of this world.

They are the foundation of my life.

- *[STATUS: COMPLETED]*
- *[THE_POINT: I AM THE ARCHITECT OF OWN PEACE]*

I look at Ghost, Shadow, and Rocket.

They are my family.

They used to be ghosts and security cameras but now they are a part of my
life.

They are the things that really mattered in the end.

Ghost is sitting next to me her fur is soft and warm.

She is a solid presence in my life.

Shadow is lying down his purr is a vibration that I can feel, and it reminds me that we are strong now.

Rocket is sitting on the railing his eyes are calm and steady.

He is just watching the world. He is not looking for threats anymore he is just enjoying the beauty of our world.

I think about the life I left behind. I think about the pain in my joints, the headaches from working on my computer for fifteen hours and the loud noise of the drones.

It feels like a story I read a time ago. It feels like a story about someone who was trying to become a person.

I am not the person I used to be. I am not the person who has to take care of everyone.

I am not the person who had to please everyone. I am the person who chose to leave all of that behind.

I am the person who bought my peace with my own experiences.

I think about the people I used to know.

I think about Waleed, Rohit, Nick, Chiyao, Abby, Alex, my father, my mother, and my sister.

They are all in my memory now.

They are all a part of my past.

I remember them clearly.

It does not hurt anymore.

I remember the times and the bad times.

I remember the chocolate, the basketball games, and the smell of the cedar shelf.

My new life is my reality now.

It is a perfect world.

I reach down and pet Ghost my hand feels her fur and her heartbeat.

She sighs; it is a sound of happiness that matches the stars. The world is stable.

Everything is okay.

The system is working right.

"Everything is a loop " I say to myself I smile as I watch a light flicker and disappear in the grass.

"I finally found the way out."

I lean back; against the house the smell of the cedar is a smell that keeps me in this moment.

I close my eyes not to escape, to finally sleep.

I am no longer a part of someone Story.

I am the person.

I am an architect.

I am home.

The game is over.

I have started a life.

The logic is closed.

[RESTART_SUCCESSFUL]
[LOGGING_OFF...]
[END_OF_FILE]

